TRAINING AND DEVELOPMENT · E2

Personal Mentor Workshop

The original skills workshop plan: purpose, session plan, case study, exercise materials, scenario cards, and after the workshop.

For	The Provincial Mentoring Team
Issue	Issue 1a (Draft for Review), October 2026: the July 2026 text set on the Provincial template
See also	E2a Personal Mentor Course, the two-hour in-person version

1 Purpose

Most Personal Mentors have never been trained to mentor - and most don't need much. What they need is confidence in a handful of skills: asking questions that open people up, listening properly, sitting with silence, spotting trouble early, and knowing where their role ends. This workshop teaches exactly that, in two hours, mostly by doing rather than being told.

It is designed for eight to sixteen participants, run by an APGMen or experienced Lodge Mentor, at Lodge or area level. Everything needed is in this guide plus one printed set per attendee of: the Personal Mentor's Guide, the Mentor Meeting Guide, the Warning Signs card, and The Hertfordshire Mentoring Principles.

2 Session Plan

Time	Segment	Facilitator notes
0.00-0.15	**The story of a man we lost**	Read the case study (Section 3) aloud. Ask the room: where were the moments this could have been turned around? List them on a flipchart - there are at least six. Land the point: none required expertise; all required someone noticing. Then the role in one sentence: a Personal Mentor is a friend with a purpose.
0.15-0.30	**What the role is - and is not**	Walk the IS/IS NOT table in the Personal Mentor's Guide. Emphasise the boundaries that free people: you are not a ritual coach, not a welfare officer, not a reporter on your mentee. Coach, not counsellor - welfare belongs to the Almoner, and referring early is the skill, not the failure.
0.30-1.00	**Exercise 1 - Questions that open doors**	Teach open vs closed in two minutes: 'Did you enjoy the ceremony?' invites 'yes'; 'What did you make of tonight?' invites the truth. In pairs, rewrite the six closed questions (Section 4) as open ones; compare answers across the room. Then pairs practise live: three minutes each way on 'What did you make of your own Initiation, all those years ago?' - a question that also reminds them what being new felt like.
1.00-1.25	**Exercise 2 - Listening, and the three-second rule**	Demonstrate bad listening for 60 seconds with a volunteer (interrupt, top their story, fill every pause) - the room will laugh in recognition. Then teach: listen for tone and hesitation, not just words; when silence falls, count to three before speaking - the mentee usually fills it, and what he says then is the real answer. Pairs repeat Exercise 1's conversation with the listener forbidden to speak except to ask one further question. Debrief: what did you hear the second time that you missed the first?
1.25-1.50	**Exercise 3 - Scenarios**	Groups of three or four take one scenario each (Section 5), ten minutes: what would you do tonight, this week, this month - and who else needs to know? Groups report back; facilitator draws out the intervention steps and hand-offs on the Warning Signs card.

1.50-2.00	**The tools, and the close**	Two minutes each on the Mentor Meeting Guide and the Stage Checklists - where they live and when to reach for them. Close with the four principles read from the canon page, and one commitment from each attendee: the first thing they will do differently with their mentee this month.

3 The Case Study

Read aloud, slowly. It is a composite drawn from real losses - every detail has happened to someone.

"I joined at thirty-four, proposed by a colleague I liked. My Initiation was extraordinary - I drove home buzzing. Then came my second meeting: nobody had told me it was mainly business, and I sat at dinner next to two men who talked across me all night about people I didn't know. At my first rehearsal evening I was told after ten minutes there was nothing for me and I should get off home. Work went mad that spring; I missed two meetings. Nobody rang. When I came back, someone at the bar said, 'Well, look who's remembered where we meet.' Everyone laughed. I laughed too. My subscription renewal came in January with a letter that read like a final demand. I paid it, and then I sat down one Sunday and wrote a different letter. The Secretary's reply was very polite. It said my resignation had been received and would be reported to the Lodge. Nobody ever asked me why."

4 Exercise 1 Materials - Six Closed Questions

- "Did you enjoy the ceremony?"
- "Are you settling in alright?"
- "Have you got any questions?"
- "Are you coming to the next meeting?"
- "Is the ritual learning going okay?"
- "Everything alright at home?"

Facilitator's model answers (do not hand out until after the exercise): What did you make of tonight? • What has surprised you most so far? • What have you been wondering about that nobody's explained? • What would make the next few months work well for you? • How are you finding the learning - what would help? • How are things generally, with work and home - how does Lodge fit around it all at the moment?

5 Scenario Cards

Scenario	Situation
A - The overwhelmed EA	Your mentee, initiated two months ago, says at the Festive Board: “Honestly, I still haven't a clue what's going on in there. Everyone else seems to just know.” He is smiling, but he has said it twice now. What do you do tonight, this week, this month?
B - The quiet drift	A Master Mason of three years - not your mentee, but you know him - has missed two consecutive meetings without apology. The Treasurer mentions his subscription is unpaid. He was passed over for Inner Guard last year. Who acts, in what order, and what is said in the first phone call?
C - The ritual dread	Your mentee has been offered his first office. He tells you privately he barely slept before his Second Degree questions and is thinking of saying no - “I'm just not a performer, and I think they'll think less of me.” What does good mentoring look like here - in both directions (to him, and to the Lodge)?
D - The eager recruiter	At the bar, a well-meaning senior Brother is pressing your recently raised mentee about joining the Chapter: “You're not a proper Mason till you've done it, you know. I'll put your name down.” Your mentee looks cornered. What do you do in the moment, and afterwards?

Debrief keys: A - normalise, the two-shocks conversation, book the one-to-one, pace the information. B - Personal Mentor or best-placed friend rings within seven days, welfare tone ('you were missed'), Treasurer's signal routed via Almoner/Lodge Mentor, under-use named as a possible cause. C - protect from pressure in both directions: no office before ready, but explore what 'ready' would need (LoI, a small first piece, shared office); his contribution is valid with or without ritual. D - rescue in the moment with grace, never embarrass the senior Brother publicly; afterwards reaffirm: information not recruitment, the decision and its timing are his alone; a quiet word via the Lodge Mentor if it recurs.

6 After the Workshop

- Names of attendees to the Lodge Mentor and APGMen; attendance noted on the Provincial register.
- Every attendee added to DAWG and told about the monthly mentoring call.
- Facilitator sends one follow-up message a month later: “What did you try, and what happened?” - modelling the very habit the workshop teaches.